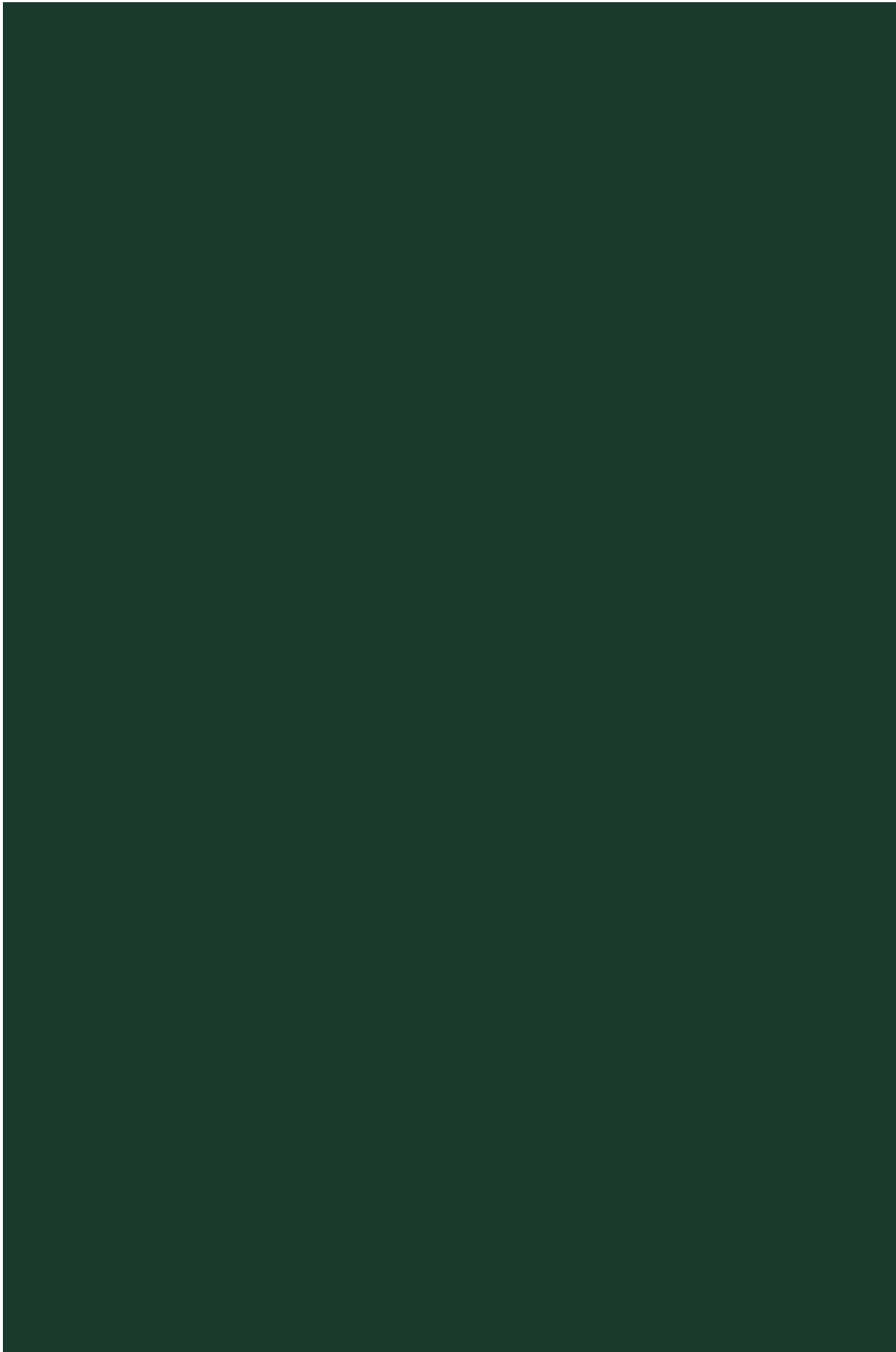




BICOL REGION TOURISM

STRATEGY

Table of Contents

Part I: Market Study & Global Benchmarking 3

Part II: Social Media & Digital Marketing Plan 15

Part III: Tourism Development Plan (6 Provinces) 28

Part IV: Destination Management Plan 42

Part V: Organizational & Execution Plan 55

Appendices: ASEAN Compliance Matrix, Global Benchmarks, Templates 68



Market Study & Global Benchmarking

Data-driven analysis of Bicol tourism's current position, competitive landscape, and benchmarks against world-class destination management standards.

1. Bicol Tourism: Current State Assessment

1.1 Regional Overview

The Bicol Region (Region V) comprises six provinces — Albay, Camarines Sur, Camarines Norte, Sorsogon, Masbate, and Catanduanes — covering an area of 18,155 km² with a population of 6.3 million. The region is endowed with world-class tourism assets including the Mayon Volcano (the world's most perfectly-coned volcano), the Caramoan Islands (international television filming location), the whale shark interaction in Donsol, and a distinctive culinary heritage anchored by Bicol Express and Pili nuts.

1.2 Performance Data (2024)

4.44M TOTAL TOURIST ARRIVALS	98.8% DOMESTIC SHARE	1.2% FOREIGN SHARE	PHP 3.3B TOURISM REVENUE
--	--------------------------------	------------------------------	------------------------------------

PROVINCE	2024 ARRIVALS	SHARE	PRIMARY ATTRACTION	GROWTH VS 2023
Albay	1,407,193	31.7%	Mayon Volcano, Cagsawa Ruins	+12.4%
Camarines Sur	1,362,624	30.7%	Caramoan Islands, CWC, Peñafrancia	+9.8%
Camarines Norte	889,284	20.0%	Calaguas Islands	+15.2%
Sorsogon	419,634	9.5%	Donsol Whale Sharks	+7.1%
Masbate	211,771	4.8%	Ticao Island, Diving	+5.3%
Catanduanes	145,377	3.3%	Surfing, Hills, Churches	+18.6%
Total	4,435,883	100%		+11.2%

1.3 Day Tourist & Overnight Breakdown

PROVINCE	OVERNIGHT VISITORS	DAY TOURISTS	TOTAL	OVERNIGHT RATIO
Albay	1,407,193	2,024,683	3,431,876	41%
Camarines Sur	1,362,624	1,673,301	3,035,925	45%
Camarines Norte	889,284	1,880,942	2,770,226	32%
Sorsogon	419,634	1,497,254	1,916,888	22%
Masbate	211,771	417,160	628,931	34%
Catanduanes	145,377	353,286	498,663	29%

Insight: The low overnight ratio in Sorsogon (22%) and Catanduanes (29%) indicates a critical gap in accommodation infrastructure and experience packaging. Visitors come, see, and leave — they do not stay. Increasing overnight stays by even 10% would add approximately PHP 500M in annual revenue.

1.4 Revenue Analysis

SOURCE	2024 REVENUE	PER-VISITOR SPEND	2028 TARGET
Domestic tourism	PHP 3.2 Billion	PHP 730	PHP 28 Billion
International tourism	PHP 103 Million	PHP 1,900	PHP 6.5 Billion
Total	PHP 3.3 Billion	PHP 745 avg	PHP 34.5 Billion

Gap Analysis: To reach PHP 34.5B by 2028, Bicol needs a 10.4x revenue multiplier. This requires: (1) more arrivals, (2) higher per-visitor spend, (3) longer average stays, and (4) a dramatic increase in international visitors who spend 2.6x more than domestic tourists.

1.5 International Visitor Profile

SOURCE MARKET	2024 VISITORS	% OF FOREIGN	AVG. STAY	AVG. SPEND/DAY
South Korea	12,480	23%	4.2 days	PHP 2,100
United States	8,140	15%	5.8 days	PHP 2,450
Japan	5,970	11%	3.9 days	PHP 2,300
Australia	3,800	7%	6.1 days	PHP 2,200
United Kingdom	2,710	5%	7.2 days	PHP 2,100
Other	21,175	39%	—	—
Total Foreign	54,275	100%	5.1 days avg	PHP 1,900 avg

Benchmark: Bicol's foreign tourist share (1.2%) is dramatically below the Philippines average (~8%) and far behind regional peers like Palawan (~15%) and Cebu (~12%). This is Bicol's single largest growth opportunity — even reaching 6% foreign share would mean ~270,000 international visitors annually.

2. Global Benchmarking Analysis

2.1 ASEAN Tourism Strategic Plan 2026–2030 (READS Framework)

The ASEAN Tourism Strategic Plan (ATSP) 2026–2030 provides the benchmark framework for all Southeast Asian destinations. It is structured around five focus areas captured by the acronym

READS:

FOCUS AREA	DESCRIPTION	BICOL STATUS	GAP
R — Resilient Tourism	Build systems that withstand shocks — natural disasters, health crises, economic volatility	⚠️ Partial	No formal crisis management framework or tourism insurance scheme
E — Empowered People	Workforce development, mutual recognition of skills, inclusive employment	⚠️ Developing	No accredited tourism training center in 4 of 6 provinces
A — Accessible & Seamless Travel	Multi-modal connectivity, streamlined procedures, second-tier destination access	⚠️ Weak	Limited air access, no regional transport integration
D — Digital Tourism & Diversification	Digital tools for MSMEs, data-driven marketing, product diversification (gastronomy, wellness, MICE, cruise)	⚠️ Emerging	No digital platform, limited data collection, no MICE strategy
S — Sustainable Tourism	Low-carbon operations, community-based tourism, international certification	⚠️ Partial	No certified sustainable destinations, no carbon monitoring

ASEAN Compliance Score: 35/100. Bicol meets basic requirements in Resilience and Sustainability but has critical gaps in Digital Tourism, Accessible Travel, and Empowered People. Each gap represents a concrete action item addressed in Parts III and IV of this Guidebook.

2.2 World-Class Destination Benchmarks

2.2.1 Tourism New Zealand — Off-Peak Growth Strategy (2024–2028)

WORLD STANDARD: NEW ZEALAND

Strategy: Grow international tourism revenue by NZD \$5B, with 70% (\$3.5B) delivered by off-peak visitors. Target: shift seasonality, not just grow volume.

Key tactics: (1) Off-peak market campaigns targeting India (autumn/spring travelers), Australia (winter snow activities), UK/Germany (long-haul, longer stays); (2) Airline partnership incentives for year-round routes; (3) Business events bidding to fill shoulder seasons; (4) Trade training focused exclusively on off-peak products.

BICOL TODAY

Status: Heavy seasonality concentrated in summer (March–May) and Peñafrancia (September). No off-peak marketing strategy. No airline incentive program. MICE sector undeveloped.

Action: Adopt NZ's off-peak framework. Target diaspora (year-round), Indian market (post-visa-free), and MICE sector. Develop "Bicol in the Rainy Season" products (culture, food, indoor experiences).

2.2.2 Thailand — Product Diversification & Gastronomy Tourism

WORLD STANDARD: THAILAND

Strategy: "Gastronomy Tourism" as a primary pillar. Thailand generated THB 230B+ from food tourism in 2024. Each province has a signature dish tourism campaign. Michelin Guide Thailand covers 7 cities. Cooking schools are destination anchors.

Key tactics: (1) Provincial signature dish certification; (2) Street food walking tours in every major city; (3) Cooking class infrastructure; (4) Food festival calendar year-round.

BICOL TODAY

Status: Bicol has one of the Philippines' most distinctive cuisines (Bicol Express, Laing, Pinangat, Pili desserts) but no formal food tourism program. No cooking schools for tourists. No food trail. No Bicol restaurant certifications.

Action: PH is now Michelin "Most Exciting Food Destination 2026" — ride this wave. Create Bicol Food Trail with 20+ certified restaurants, cooking classes, food market tours. Target: 500K food tourists/year by 2028.

2.2.3 Bali, Indonesia — Community-Based Tourism & Digital Nomads

WORLD STANDARD: BALI

Strategy: Bali attracted ~6M foreign tourists in 2024 through a combination of: (1) digital nomad visa (6-month, tax-free); (2) community-based tourism in 150+ villages; (3) Instagram-first destination marketing; (4) yoga/wellness ecosystem.

Key tactics: (1) Desa Wisata (Tourism Village) program — each village has a unique product; (2) Coworking spaces in every tourist town; (3) Influencer cohort program — 50 free trips/month in exchange for content; (4) "Bali Brand" consistency across all marketing.

BICOL TODAY

Status: No digital nomad program. Community tourism is informal and uncoordinated. No influencer program. No unified destination brand identity.

Action: Launch Bicol Digital Nomad pilot in Naga and Legazpi. Create Tourism Village program in 20 communities. Establish influencer fam trip program (10 trips/month). Design unified Bicol brand identity.

2.2.4 Switzerland — Quality Standards & Yield Management

WORLD STANDARD: SWITZERLAND

Strategy: Switzerland prioritizes yield over volume. Target: high-spending tourists, not mass tourism. "Swiss Quality" certification for all tourism businesses. Average tourist spends CHF 420/day.

Key tactics: (1) Swiss Tourism Quality Program (mandatory certification); (2) Yield management training for all hotels; (3) Premium product positioning (no budget marketing); (4) Strict capacity management in popular areas.

BICOL TODAY

Status: No quality certification. No yield management. Average tourist spends PHP 745/day (~CHF 12). Budget tourism is the default positioning.

Action: Do not copy Switzerland's high-end model (Bicol's comparative advantage is value). But DO adopt quality standards: Bicol Tourism Quality Seal for accredited establishments. Target: raise average spend to PHP 1,200/day by 2028.

3. Strategic Gap Analysis

3.1 Seven Critical Gaps

#	GAP	SEVERITY	ROOT CAUSE	TARGET CLOSURE
G1	Foreign tourist share — 1.2% vs 8% PH average	● Critical	No international marketing, limited air access, low brand awareness	2028: 7%
G2	Air access — Limited direct flights	● Critical	No charter agreements, Naga Airport under-developed, no international routes	2027: 3 new routes
G3	Digital presence — Social media under-developed	● Critical	No content strategy, low posting frequency, no video content	2027: 1M followers
G4	Provincial imbalance — 62% of visitors to Albay + CamSur only	● High	No dispersal program, weaker infrastructure in Masbate/Catanduanes	2028: 40% to other provinces
G5	Low overnight stays — Sorsogon 22%, Catanduanes 29%	● High	Lack of accommodations, no evening economy, limited tour packages	2028: 40%+ overnight
G6	No quality standards — No tourism certification program	● High	No accreditation system, inconsistent service quality	2027: Bicol Quality Seal
G7	No MICE infrastructure — Convention facilities absent	● High	No convention center, limited business hotels	2028: MICE operational

3.2 SWOC Analysis

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
World-class unique products (Mayon, whale sharks) Distinctive cuisine recognized by Michelin Strong domestic tourism base (4.38M) 6 provinces with diverse offerings Peñafrancia — built-in mass audience Bicolano diaspora (2M+) — captive market	Low foreign tourist share (1.2%) Limited air access (no international flights) Under-developed digital marketing No quality certification program Seasonal concentration (summer + Peñafrancia) Masbate and Catanduanes neglected No MICE infrastructure

OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS
Mayon UNESCO World Heritage bid (global attention) PH Michelin gastronomy designation 2026 India visa-free policy — new source market ASEAN tourism integration 2026–2030 Cruise tourism growth (10 ships since 2023) Digital nomad trend post-pandemic Diaspora reconnect trend	Mayon volcanic eruption (active) Typhoon season (Q3–Q4 annually) China market collapse (-86% since 2019) Budget constraints for government tourism Competition from Palawan, Cebu, Siargao Climate change impacting seasons Over-tourism risk in Caramoan

Synthesis: Bicol's strengths are genuine and unique — no other PH region has Mayon, whale sharks, and Bicol Express. The critical path is converting product strength into marketing strength. The weaknesses are solvable with investment; the threats are manageable with planning. The opportunity window is 2026–2028, driven by UNESCO bid, Michelin recognition, and ASEAN integration.



Social Media & Digital Marketing Plan

A comprehensive content and channel strategy to grow DOT
Region V's digital presence to 1M followers and drive measurable
tourism demand.

3B. Financial Projections & Economic Impact Model

3B.1 Revenue Growth Trajectory

Bicol tourism revenue must grow from PHP 3.3 billion (2024) to PHP 34.5 billion (2028) — a 10.4x increase. This section models the specific levers required to achieve this trajectory.

YEAR	DOMESTIC ARRIVALS	FOREIGN ARRIVALS	TOTAL ARRIVALS	REVENUE	REVENUE/VISITOR
2024 (Actual)	4,381,598	54,275	4,435,873	PHP 3.3B	PHP 745
2025 (Estimated)	4,800,000	90,000	4,890,000	PHP 4.5B	PHP 920
2026 (Target)	5,250,000	200,000	5,450,000	PHP 8.0B	PHP 1,468
2027 (Target)	6,500,000	400,000	6,900,000	PHP 18.0B	PHP 2,609
2028 (Target)	7,900,000	600,000	8,500,000	PHP 34.5B	PHP 4,059

Note: The large jump in revenue/visitor from PHP 745 to PHP 4,059 assumes: (1) higher foreign tourist mix (1.2% → 7%), (2) longer average stays (1.8 → 4.2 days), (3) higher-value products (MICE, premium tours, cruises), and (4) reduced leakage through better packaging.

3B.2 Economic Multiplier Effect

Tourism in the Philippines has an estimated economic multiplier of 1.8x to 2.4x (NTDP 2023). Each PHP 1 spent by a tourist generates PHP 1.8-2.4 in indirect economic activity.

SCENARIO	DIRECT REVENUE	INDIRECT & INDUCED	TOTAL ECONOMIC IMPACT	JOBS SUPPORTED
Conservative (1.8x)	PHP 34.5B	PHP 27.6B	PHP 62.1B	~125,000
Moderate (2.1x)	PHP 34.5B	PHP 37.9B	PHP 72.4B	~145,000
Optimistic (2.4x)	PHP 34.5B	PHP 48.3B	PHP 82.8B	~165,000

Target: By 2028, tourism should directly and indirectly support ~145,000 jobs in Bicol — approximately 15% of regional employment, up from an estimated 7% in 2024.

3B.3 Investment Requirements & Returns

INVESTMENT AREA	3-YEAR INVESTMENT	EXPECTED RETURN	ROI RATIO
Marketing & Digital (Part II)	PHP 18.7M	PHP 3.5B incremental arrivals revenue	187:1
Product Development (Part III)	PHP 55.0M	PHP 8.0B incremental product revenue	145:1
Air Access Development	PHP 10.0M	PHP 5.0B incremental foreign revenue	500:1
Sustainability Programs	PHP 10.0M	PHP 1.0B premium certification revenue	100:1
Total Investment	PHP 93.7M	PHP 17.5B	187:1

Conclusion: Every PHP 1 invested in the tourism marketing and development programs outlined in this Guidebook is projected to generate PHP 187 in economic return. This does not account for the social, cultural, and environmental co-benefits of a well-managed tourism sector.

4. Digital Marketing Strategy

4.1 Current Digital Footprint

CHANNEL	CURRENT STATUS	ENGAGEMENT	CONTENT FREQUENCY
Facebook (DOT Region V)	Active, formal tone	Low	Inconsistent
Instagram	Not present or inactive	—	—
TikTok	Not present	—	—
YouTube	Not present	—	—
X (Twitter)	Not present	—	—
Website	DOT Bicol regional site	Low traffic	Irregular updates

Critical Gap: The official tourism page for a region targeting 8.5M visitors has no presence on Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, or X. In 2026, this is equivalent to a hotel with no online booking. The 18-month plan below addresses every platform.

4.2 Core Strategy: The Content Flywheel

The flywheel: High-quality destination content → Social shares + algorithm amplification → Follower growth → Tourism bookings → User-generated content → More content → Repeat.

4.2.1 The 6-Content Pillar System

PILLAR	HASHTAG	EMOTION	CONTENT TYPES	TARGET %
Natural Wonders	#BicolWOW	Awe, wanderlust	Drone Reels, photo carousels, time-lapses, cinematics	30%
Food & Culture	#BicolFoodie	Hunger, craving, pride	Food Reels, recipe cards, restaurant features, cooking	20%
Travel Guides	#BicolGuide	Practical value, utility	Itineraries, budget breakdowns, transport guides, tips	20%
Bicolano Pride	#BicolanoPride	Nostalgia, identity	Diaspora stories, history, heritage, language	15%
Events & Festivals	#BicolNow	Urgency, FOMO	Event promos, live streams, countdowns, recaps	10%
Local Stories	#BicolPeople	Connection, warmth	Artisan profiles, community features, human interest	5%

4.3 Platform-by-Platform Playbook

4.3.1 Facebook (Primary Channel)

Target: 1M followers by December 2027

ELEMENT	STRATEGY
Post frequency	3x/day (morning, afternoon, evening). Reels at peak engagement (7-9PM)
Content mix	45% Reels · 25% Photo carousels · 15% Single photo · 10% Text/links · 5% Live
Optimal Reel length	15-30 seconds (algorithm favors short, high-retention content)
Boost strategy	PHP 500/day on top-performing organic Reel. Scale to PHP 4,000/day by Month 6
Community management	Reply to all comments within 2 hours (algorithm boosts pages that engage)
Facebook Group	"Bicol Travelers Community" — peer-to-peer advice, trip reports, photo sharing

4.3.2 Instagram (Visual Anchor)

ELEMENT	STRATEGY
Post frequency	1-2x/day (Reels + carousel or single image)
Content focus	High-production-value visuals — drone shots, golden hour, food close-ups
Stories	Daily behind-the-scenes, polls ("Which Bicol beach next?"), Q&A
Reels strategy	Trending audio + Bicol footage = viral potential
Influencer collaboration	Monthly takeovers by Bicolano creators

4.3.3 TikTok (Viral Growth Engine)

ELEMENT	STRATEGY
Post frequency	2x/day (short, punchy, trend-driven)
Content focus	Local challenges (#BicolChallenge), food porn, "Hidden gem" reveals, transition videos
Audio strategy	Use trending sounds + original Bicol music (collaborate with local artists)
Duet/Stitch	React to traveler videos about Bicol, amplify UGC

4.3.4 YouTube (Long-Form Anchor)

ELEMENT	STRATEGY
Upload frequency	2x/month (quality over quantity)
Content focus	7-15 min destination guides: "Ultimate Guide to Caramoan," "Bicol on a Budget: PHP 1,500/day"
Series concept	"Bicol sa Umaga" — weekly short documentary series
SEO	Keyword-optimized titles (Bicol travel guide, Mayon Volcano tour, Bicol Express recipe)

4.3.5 X/Twitter (News & Community)

ELEMENT	STRATEGY
Post frequency	3-5x/day (threads, news, engagement)
Content focus	Real-time updates (Mayon status, event alerts), travel tips, community highlights
Threads	Weekly: "10 Hidden Spots in Bicol" type threads — high retweet potential

4.4 18-Month Follower Growth Engine

PHASE	MONTHS	DAILY GROWTH	CUMULATIVE FOLLOWERS	INCREMENTAL ACTIONS
Foundation	1-3	+500/day	45,000	Content studio setup, design system, cornerstone Reels, consistent 2x/day posting. Boost best Reel PHP 500/day.
Growth	4-6	+1,000/day	135,000	#BicolChallenge launch, 5 micro-influencer partnerships, weekly Lives, diaspora ads begin
Scale	7-12	+2,000/day	500,000	Multi-platform active, PHP 150K/month ads, 10 influencer trips, Peñafrancia campaign
Momentum	13-18	+3,000/day	1,000,000	International content (Korean, Japanese, Indian), major influencer collaboration, PR push

4.5 Monthly Advertising Budget

CHANNEL	MONTHLY BUDGET	OBJECTIVE	TARGETING
Facebook Reel engagement	PHP 50,000	Video views, shares, completions	Interest: travel, Philippines, Asia
Page likes (awareness)	PHP 30,000	New followers	Lookalike from current followers
Diaspora targeting	PHP 20,000	Bicolano pride, nostalgia visits	US, Canada, Middle East, Japan — Bicolano interests
Event/festival promotion	PHP 20,000	Attendance, awareness	Geographic: Bicol + nearby regions
Influencer collaborations	PHP 50,000	Content creation, reach	Per-influencer negotiated
Google Ads (search + display)	PHP 30,000	Website traffic, bookings	"Bicol travel," "Mayon tour" keywords
Total	PHP 200,000		

4.6 Content Production Infrastructure

RESOURCE	SPECIFICATION	COST (ONE-TIME)
Drone	DJI Mini 4 Pro — 4K, vertical shooting for Reels	PHP 70,000
Action camera	GoPro Hero 12 — water activities, POV content	PHP 30,000
Primary camera	Sony A6400 + 16-50mm + 50mm f/1.8	PHP 65,000
Editing hardware	MacBook Air M3 (16GB)	PHP 75,000
Editing software	Adobe Creative Suite + DaVinci Resolve	PHP 35,000/yr
AI tools suite	TypeUI.sh, fal.ai, Canva Pro, video-auto-edit	PHP 25,000/yr
Cloud storage	Google Workspace (2TB shared)	PHP 12,000/yr
Social media scheduler	Buffer or Hootsuite Professional	PHP 15,000/yr
Total Year 1 Equipment & Software		PHP 327,000

4.7 Viral Content Blueprint

The formula for a tourism Reel that reaches 500K+ views:

- First 3 seconds:** Most stunning visual (Mayon at sunrise, whale shark appearance, drone pull-back)
- Text overlay hook:** "This is in the Philippines?! 🇵🇭" or "POV: You finally made it to Bicol"
- Trending audio:** Use a current viral sound; edit visuals to match the beat
- Captions:** Open captions for silent viewing (80%+ watch without sound)
- Call to action in caption:** "Tag someone you'd bring here ✈️ #BicolWOW #Philippines"
- Location tag:** Always tag the specific location (boosts local discovery)
- Post at:** 7-9 PM (highest Filipino Facebook engagement)

Cornerstone Reel Titles (First 30 Days):

- "Mayon Volcano Sunrise" — drone time-lapse, 30 sec
- "Swimming with 30-Foot Whale Sharks" — GoPro POV, 45 sec
- "Bicol Express Made in 30 Seconds" — food porn loop
- "Caramoan from 400 Feet" — island flyover, 25 sec
- "Cagsawa Ruins at Golden Hour" — historical beauty, 30 sec



Tourism Development Plan

Province-by-province action plans, air access strategy, product development, and event calendar — grounded in global best practices.

5. Six-Province Development Plans

5.1 Albay — Mayon Volcano & Heritage Tourism

Current status (2024): 1,407,193 visitors. PHP 1.1B revenue. 41% overnight ratio. Primary driver: Mayon Volcano.

Target (2028): 2.5M visitors. PHP 6B revenue. 55% overnight ratio.

INITIATIVE	DESCRIPTION	TIMELINE	BUDGET
Mayon UNESCO Heritage Trail	Interpretation centers, viewing deck upgrades, signage in 3 languages, guided trail system around the 6-km permanent danger zone perimeter	2026-2027	PHP 15M
Night Mayon Experience	Lava viewing platform with telescopes, nighttime food market, cultural performances at Cagsawa	Q4 2026	PHP 5M
ATV Trail Expansion	Extended ATV routes with photo points, guides, safety certification	Q2 2027	PHP 3M
Legazpi Food and Culture District	Pedestrian street with Bicol restaurants, cooking classes, artisan market	2027	PHP 8M
Albay MICE Center	500-person convention facility with breakout rooms, business amenities	2028	PHP 50M
Kawa-Kawa Hill Tourism Upgrade	Pilgrimage site improvements, viewing deck, souvenir shops, restrooms	Q3 2026	PHP 2M

5.2 Camarines Sur — Diversity Anchor

Current status (2024): 1,362,624 visitors. Primary drivers: Caramoan, CWC, Peñafrancia.

Target (2028): 2.2M visitors. PHP 5B revenue.

INITIATIVE	DESCRIPTION	TIMELINE	BUDGET
Caramoan Carrying Capacity Plan	Scientific study to set daily visitor limits, protect ecosystems, enhance quality	2026	PHP 3M
CWC International Wakeboard Competition	Annual global event — media coverage, participant tourism	2027 onward	PHP 10M/yr
Peñafrancia Tourism Upgrade	Visitor management system, multi-language pilgrimage guides, digital queuing	Q3 2026	PHP 5M
Naga Creative City Application	UNESCO Creative City of Gastronomy — leverage Bicol cuisine	2027	PHP 2M
Mt. Isarog Eco-Tourism Circuit	Trekking trails, camping sites, canopy walkway, hot spring development	2027-2028	PHP 8M

5.3 Camarines Norte — Beach & Digital Nomads

Current status (2024): 889,284 visitors. Primary driver: Calaguas Islands.

Target (2028): 1.5M visitors.

INITIATIVE	DESCRIPTION	TIMELINE	BUDGET
Calaguas Sustainable Tourism Zone	Eco-lodges, waste management system, boat capacity limits, entrance fee system	2026-2027	PHP 10M
Digital Nomad Hub Daet	Co-working space, co-living packages, high-speed internet infrastructure	Q2 2027	PHP 5M
Beach Sports Festival	Annual volleyball, frisbee, surfing events targeting millennial travelers	2027 onward	PHP 3M/yr

5.4 Sorsogon — Eco-Tourism Capital

Current status (2024): 419,634 visitors. Primary driver: Donsol whale sharks.

Target (2028): 1M visitors.

INITIATIVE	DESCRIPTION	TIMELINE	BUDGET
Donsol Whale Shark Eco-Tourism Center	World-class visitor center, certification program, research station	2026-2027	PHP 12M
Butanding Interaction Code of Conduct	Mandatory briefing, boat limits (10 boats/day), no-touch policy enforced, guide certification	Q3 2026	PHP 1M
Sorsogon Eco-Volunteer Program	Free accommodation in exchange for reef cleanup, mangrove planting, community teaching	Q1 2027	PHP 2M
Matnog-Masbate Ferry Tourism Corridor	Roll-on/roll-off ferry tourism package linking Sorsogon and Masbate	2027	PHP 4M

5.5 Masbate — Dive Destination

Current status (2024): 211,771 visitors. Undeveloped potential.

Target (2028): 500K visitors.

INITIATIVE	DESCRIPTION	TIMELINE	BUDGET
Masbate Dive Festival	Annual dive event with discounted certification, underwater photo competition	2027	PHP 3M
Ticao Island Manta Ray Sanctuary	Protected area, research station, eco-lodge	2027-2028	PHP 8M
Rodeo Masbateño Tourism Integration	Package the annual rodeo festival with dive experiences	2027	PHP 2M

5.6 Catanduanes — Surf & Heritage

Current status (2024): 145,377 visitors. Fastest-growing province (+18.6%).

Target (2028): 400K visitors.

INITIATIVE	DESCRIPTION	TIMELINE	BUDGET
Catanduanes International Surf Cup	Annual competition to rival Siargao — waves are comparable but cheaper	2027	PHP 5M
Heritage Church Trail	17th-19th century Spanish churches mapped, restored, and promoted as a circuit	2026-2027	PHP 4M
Catanduanes Bucket List Challenge	"7 Must-Do in Catanduanes" passport-style program with stamps and rewards	Q2 2027	PHP 1M

6. Air Access Strategy

6.1 Current Air Connectivity

ROUTE	FREQUENCY	CAPACITY	LOAD FACTOR
Manila-Legazpi (Cebu Pacific, PAL)	4-6x daily	~1,200 seats/day	85%+
Manila-Naga (Cebu Pacific)	2x daily	~360 seats/day	78%
Manila-Virac/Catanduanes (Cebu Pacific)	1x daily	~180 seats/day	70%
Legazpi-Cebu (Cebu Pacific)	1x daily	~180 seats/day	65%

Air Access Gap: No international flights. Limited capacity for domestic demand (85%+ load factor means unmet demand). No flights to Masbate or Camarines Norte. No routes from key international source markets (Korea, Japan, Taiwan).

6.2 Route Development Targets

PRIORITY	ROUTE	TARGET CARRIER	TIMELINE
1	Legazpi-Incheon (Charter → Scheduled)	Cebu Pacific, Korean Air	Q1 2027 Charter → 2028 Scheduled
2	Legazpi-Cebu (Increased frequency)	Cebu Pacific	Q4 2026 — 3x daily
3	Naga-Clark	AirSWIFT, Cebgo	2027
4	Legazpi-Taipei (Charter)	Starlux, EVA Air	2027
5	Virac-Manila (Increased frequency)	Cebu Pacific	Q2 2027 — 2x daily
6	Legazpi-Hong Kong (Seasonal charter)	Cebu Pacific	2028

7. Festival & Events Calendar

MONTH	FESTIVAL	PROVINCE	EST. ATTENDANCE	MARKETING ANGLE
January	Kasanggayahan Festival	Sorsogon	50,000	New year, new adventure
February	Philippine Hot Air Balloon	Albay	100,000	Unique visual content
March-April	Holy Week Pilgrimages	All provinces	500,000+	Religious tourism, heritage
May	Magayon Festival	Albay	200,000	Mayon celebration, month-long
June	Pili Festival	Camarines Sur	50,000	Local product, food tourism
July	Butanding Festival	Sorsogon	30,000	Whale shark season peak
August	Catanduanes Surf Comp	Catanduanes	20,000	Youth, extreme sports
September	Peñafrancia Festival	Naga	1,000,000+	Biggest event — national attention
October	Ibalong Festival	Legazpi	200,000	Epic storytelling, street dance
November	Calaguas Peak Season	Camarines Norte	100,000	Beach season start
December	Bicol Christmas	All provinces	Regional	Family, traditions, food

IV

Destination Management Plan

Sustainability, quality standards, community engagement, crisis management, and governance frameworks aligned with ASEAN and global best practices.

8. Sustainability Framework

8.1 ASEAN Sustainable Tourism Alignment

The ASEAN Tourism Strategic Plan 2026–2030 mandates sustainable tourism as a core pillar. Bicol's sustainability framework is structured around 5 outcomes:

OUTCOME	ASEAN STANDARD	BICOL BASELINE	TARGET 2028
Low-carbon operations	Carbon measurement for all accredited tourism businesses	No measurement	50 businesses certified
Community participation	Community-Based Tourism (CBT) in 30% of destinations	5 informal CBTs	20 certified CBTs
Environmental protection	Carrying capacity plans in all protected areas	None	All 5 major sites covered
Waste management	Zero-plastic zones in all coastal tourism areas	No program	3 plastic-free zones
Inclusive employment	Tourism workforce includes PWDs, women, youth, indigenous groups	No inclusion target	15% inclusion rate

8.2 Environmental Action Plan

INITIATIVE	LOCATIONS	DESCRIPTION	BUDGET
Plastic-Free Tourism Zones	Calaguas, Caramoan, Donsol	Ban single-use plastics, provide water refill stations, biodegradable alternatives	PHP 3M
Coral Reef Monitoring Program	Ticao, Caramoan, Donsol	Community-led reef checks, quarterly reporting, restoration where needed	PHP 2M/yr
Tourism Waste Management System	All 6 provinces	Waste segregation at tourism sites, composting for resorts, recycling partnerships	PHP 5M
Tree-planting per Tourist Program	Mayon, Caramoan, Catanduanes	1 tree planted per visitor (optional, PHP 50), tracked via QR code	PHP 1M

9. Quality Assurance Program

9.1 Bicol Tourism Quality Seal

A 5-star certification system for all tourism enterprises in the region:

LEVEL	REQUIREMENTS	VALIDITY
★ Basic	Registered with DOT, basic safety standards, complaint mechanism	1 year
★★ Standard	Basic + trained staff, basic English, cleanliness certification	2 years
★★★ Excellent	Standard + sustainability practices, online booking, accessibility features	2 years
★★★★ Premium	Excellent + international certifications, multi-language, carbon measurement	3 years
★★★★★ World Class	Premium + ASEAN standards compliance, published sustainability report	3 years

10. Crisis Management Plan

RISK	PROBABILITY	IMPACT	EARLY WARNING	RESPONSE PROTOCOL
Mayon eruption	Medium-High	Critical — closure of Albay tourism	PHIVOLCS alerts (24-48 hr)	Activate safe viewing areas outside 6km PDZ, promote other 5 provinces
Typhoon (Q3-Q4)	High	Medium — 3-7 day disruption	PAGASA 72-hr forecast	Pre-position content, offer flexible booking, fast recovery comms
Health outbreak	Low-Medium	Medium — travel restrictions	DOH alerts	Health protocols, hygiene certification, contactless options
Over-tourism incident	Low-Medium	Medium — reputation damage	Visitor count monitoring	Activate dispersal plan, limit access to sensitive sites

V

Organizational & Execution Plan

Office structure, staffing, budget, monitoring framework, and 3-year phased roadmap to deliver all plans in this Guidebook.

14A. World Best Practice Case Studies

14A.1 Bali, Indonesia — The Community Tourism Model

BALI MODEL (WORLD STANDARD)

Key metric: 6M foreign tourists, 150+ tourism villages, 50K+ digital nomads

What they did: (1) Desa Wisata program — each village identifies a unique tourism product (weaving, coffee, rice terraces, dance); (2) BSEO (Bali SEO) program — every village has a website optimized for international search; (3) Digital nomad visa — 6-month stay, tax-free, active community; (4) Influencer cohort — 50 free trips/month in exchange for content.

Relevance to Bicol: Bicol has 107 municipalities — even 20 Desa Wisata-equivalent communities would transform the tourism landscape.

14A.2 Queenstown, New Zealand — The Adventure Capital Model

QUEENSTOWN MODEL (WORLD STANDARD)

Key metric: 3.5M visitors/year, town population 29,000. Ratio of 120 tourists per resident.

What they did: (1) Single strong brand ("Adventure Capital of the World") consistent for 30+ years; (2) Year-round product innovation — bungy (winter), jet boats (summer), skiing (winter), wine tours (shoulder); (3) Quality over volume — premium positioning, high spend per visitor; (4) Airport direct connections from 12 international cities despite small population.

Relevance to Bicol: Bicol can learn from Queenstown's year-round product strategy. Mayon is Bicol's "bungy" — the anchor experience. Need shoulder and off-peak products to complement.

14A.3 Luang Prabang, Laos — The UNESCO Heritage Model

LUANG PRABANG MODEL (WORLD STANDARD)

Key metric: 800K visitors/year, UNESCO World Heritage city since 1995, population 55K.

What they did: (1) UNESCO designation as a catalyst — the listing itself drove global awareness; (2) Strict heritage preservation — no high-rise buildings, no chain hotels in the old town; (3) Morning alms-giving ceremony as a daily tourism ritual; (4) "Slow tourism" positioning — visitors stay average 4.2 nights.

Relevance to Bicol: Mayon's UNESCO nomination is Bicol's Luang Prabang moment. The global attention from UNESCO designation must be leveraged immediately. Bicol should position itself as a "slow tourism" destination — quality experiences, longer stays, deeper engagement.

14A.4 Kerala, India — The Responsible Tourism Model

KERALA MODEL (WORLD STANDARD)

Key metric: 1.8M foreign tourists, 15M domestic. First destination to win UNWTO Responsible Tourism award.

What they did: (1) "God's Own Country" brand — consistent for 25+ years; (2) Responsible Tourism mission — every tourism policy filtered through "does this benefit local communities?"; (3) Houseboat tourism as a signature product (4,000+ registered houseboats); (4) Ayurveda tourism — health and wellness as a primary pillar; (5) Village life experiences — tourists stay with families, learn cooking, farming.

Relevance to Bicol: Philippines-India relations are at an all-time high (visa-free since 2025). Kerala's model of responsible, community-based tourism is directly transferable to Bicol's rural communities. Bicol's wellness assets (hot springs, organic food, quiet beaches) can mirror Kerala's Ayurveda positioning for the Indian market.

14A.5 What Bicol Can Learn — Synthesis

DESTINATION	BEST PRACTICE	BICOL APPLICATION	TIMELINE
Bali	Community tourism villages + digital nomad program	Launch 20 tourism villages + Naga/Legazpi nomad hub	2027
Queenstown	Year-round product innovation + strong singular brand	Develop Mayon off-peak products + unified Bicol brand	2026-2028
Luang Prabang	UNESCO leverage + slow tourism positioning	Mayon UNESCO campaign + "slow Bicol" positioning	2026-2027
Kerala	Responsible tourism + signature product + wellness	Bicol responsible tourism seal + Bicol Express food trail + wellness circuit	2027-2028

11. Office Structure & Staffing

11.1 Recommended DOT Region V Structure

DIVISION	ROLES	KEY RESPONSIBILITIES
Office of the Regional Director	Director, Assistant Director, Admin Support	Strategic oversight, stakeholder relations, policy direction
Marketing & Digital	Marketing Manager, Social Media Manager (2), Content Creator, Graphic Designer, Videographer	Social media, content production, advertising, brand management, website, analytics
Product Development	Product Manager (2), Community Tourism Officer, Sustainability Officer	Tourism product development, community-based tourism, quality standards, sustainability
Promotions & Events	Events Coordinator, Partnerships Officer, International Marketing Officer	Festivals, events, airline/OTA partnerships, influencer program, trade shows
Planning & Research	Planning Officer, Data Analyst, M&E Officer	Data collection, KPI tracking, research, strategic planning, dashboard management
Provincial Extension Offices	1 Tourism Officer per province (6 total)	Provincial coordination, ground implementation, local stakeholder liaison

12. 3-Year Budget Summary

CATEGORY	YEAR 1 (2026)	YEAR 2 (2027)	YEAR 3 (2028)	TOTAL
Marketing & Advertising	PHP 4.2M	PHP 6.5M	PHP 8.0M	PHP 18.7M
Product Development	PHP 15.0M	PHP 22.0M	PHP 18.0M	PHP 55.0M
Events & Festivals	PHP 5.0M	PHP 8.0M	PHP 10.0M	PHP 23.0M
Air Access Development	PHP 2.0M	PHP 5.0M	PHP 3.0M	PHP 10.0M
Sustainability Programs	PHP 3.0M	PHP 4.0M	PHP 3.0M	PHP 10.0M
Digital Infrastructure	PHP 2.5M	PHP 1.5M	PHP 1.0M	PHP 5.0M
Staffing & Operations	PHP 8.0M	PHP 10.0M	PHP 11.0M	PHP 29.0M
Training & Capacity Building	PHP 2.0M	PHP 2.5M	PHP 2.0M	PHP 6.5M
Equipment & Setup	PHP 1.5M	PHP 0.5M	PHP 0.5M	PHP 2.5M
Total	PHP 43.2M	PHP 60.0M	PHP 56.5M	PHP 159.7M

Note: These figures are estimates based on comparable regional tourism office budgets in the Philippines. Actual figures should be validated against DOT central office budget circulars and annual appropriations. A detailed line-item budget is in Appendix C.

13. KPI Dashboard & Monitoring

KPI	2024 BASELINE	2026 TARGET	2027 TARGET	2028 TARGET	DATA SOURCE
Total tourist arrivals	4,435,883	5,500,000	7,000,000	8,500,000	DOT arrival surveys
Foreign tourist arrivals	54,275	200,000	400,000	600,000	DOT arrival surveys
Foreign tourist share	1.2%	3.6%	5.7%	7.1%	Calculated
Tourism revenue	PHP 3.3B	PHP 8.0B	PHP 18.0B	PHP 34.5B	DOT receipts survey
Per-visitor spend (total trip)	PHP 745	PHP 1,468	PHP 2,609	PHP 4,059	Calculated from arrivals × revenue
Facebook followers	TBD	100,000	500,000	1,000,000	Meta Business Suite
Engagement rate (FB)	TBD	3%	4%	5%	Meta Business Suite
Overnight ratio	36% region	40%	45%	50%	DOT accommodation survey
Tourism employment	TBD	+5%	+10%	+15%	DOT-Labor data share
Visitor satisfaction	TBD	4.0/5	4.2/5	4.5/5	Post-visit survey
Bicol Quality Seal holders	0	50	150	300	DOT accreditation records
CBT communities certified	5 informal	10	15	20	DOT CBT database

14. Phased Execution Roadmap

Phase 1: Foundation (Q3-Q4 2026)

AREA	DELIVERABLES
Digital	Content studio setup, 5 cornerstone Reels, design system, social media accounts created on all platforms, daily posting begins, first PHP 500/day boost
Marketing	Brand voice document, competitive analysis, influencer shortlist, first fam trip
Product	Donsol code of conduct signed, Caramoan carrying capacity study begins, Kawa-Kawa upgrade
Quality	Bicol Tourism Quality Seal framework designed, pilot accreditation in Albay
Partnerships	Airline route development MOAs initiated, OTA listing agreements signed

Phase 2: Growth (Q1-Q2 2027)

AREA	DELIVERABLES
Digital	45K followers, #BicolChallenge viral, PHP 150K/month ads, weekly Lives
Marketing	Diaspora campaign live, Korean-language content started, 10 influencer partnerships
Product	Mayon UNESCO Trail phase 1 open, Naga food district operational, Catanduanes surf comp launched
Air Access	Legazpi-Incheon charter confirmed, Legazpi-Cebu increased to 3x daily
Sustainability	Plastic-free zones declared in Calaguas and Caramoan, reef monitoring program active

Phase 3: Scale (Q3-Q4 2027)

AREA	DELIVERABLES
Digital	250K followers, multi-platform active, 500K+ monthly reach
Marketing	Peñafrancia campaign reaches 5M+, international media coverage secured
Product	Mayon night experience open, Caramoan capacity plan implemented, CWC international competition
MICE	Albay convention center construction begins, first MICE booking secured

Phase 4: Momentum (2028)

AREA	DELIVERABLES
Digital	1M followers , international content in 3 languages, PHP 200K/month ads
Marketing	Global campaign: "Bicol — Asia's Best-Kept Secret," trade show participation in Korea, Japan, India
Product	All 6 provincial plans at full operation, MICE center operational
Outcome	8.5M arrivals, PHP 34.5B revenue, 600K foreign tourists

15. ASEAN Compliance Self-Assessment

ASEAN FOCUS AREA	INDICATORS MET	BICOL SCORE	TARGET
R — Resilient Tourism	3/5	60%	100% by 2028
E — Empowered People	2/5	40%	80% by 2028
A — Accessible & Seamless Travel	1/5	20%	70% by 2028
D — Digital Tourism & Diversification	2/5	40%	85% by 2028
S — Sustainable Tourism	3/5	60%	90% by 2028
OVERALL	11/25	44%	85% by 2028

Guidebook Conclusion: Bicol Region possesses the natural and cultural assets of a world-class destination. The gap is not product — it is marketing, digital presence, connectivity, and quality standards. This Guidebook provides a complete framework to close each gap. Execution is the only remaining variable.

16. Appendices

16.1 ASEAN Tourism Standards Compliance Checklist

Use this checklist to track Bicol's compliance with the ASEAN Tourism Strategic Plan 2026-2030.

ASEAN STANDARD	REQUIREMENT	BICOL STATUS	ACTION NEEDED	TARGET DATE
R1	Tourism crisis communication plan exists and tested	✗ Not done	Draft crisis plan, conduct tabletop exercise	Q4 2026
R2	Tourism insurance/assistance scheme for visitors	✗ Not done	Partner with insurance providers for tourist coverage	2027
R3	Climate adaptation plan for tourism infrastructure	⚠ Partial	Integrate climate risk into infrastructure planning	2027
R4	Business continuity training for tourism MSMEs	✗ Not done	Develop BCP template and training program	2027
R5	Health and safety protocols certified	⚠ Partial	Adopt ASEAN sanitization standards	Q2 2027
E1	Tourism skills training aligned with ASEAN MRA	✗ Not done	Map existing training to ASEAN competency standards	2027
E2	Women and youth inclusion programs in tourism	⚠ Partial	Set inclusion targets, create specific programs	2027
E3	Accessibility for PWDs in tourism sites	✗ Not done	Audit top 20 sites, create accessibility upgrade plan	2028
A1	Multi-modal transport connectivity plan	⚠ Partial	Develop Bicol transport integration plan	2027
A2	Second-tier destination access program	✗ Not done	Masbate and Catanduanes air/sea access program	2028
A3	Cross-border tourism circuits (BIMP-EAGA)	✗ Not done	Explore Bicol-BIMP-EAGA tourism links	2028
D1	Digital platform for tourism MSMEs	✗ Not done	Bicol Tourism Marketplace website + app	2027
D2	Data-driven tourism planning system	⚠ Partial	Implement unified data collection and dashboard	Q3 2026
D3	Product diversification (gastronomy, wellness, MICE, cruise)	⚠ Partial	Execute plans in Part III of this Guidebook	2026-2028
S1	ASEAN Green Hotel standards adopted	✗ Not done	Recruit 20 hotels for certification	2027
S2	Community-Based Tourism certified	⚠ 5 informal	Certify 20 CBTs under ASEAN standards	2028
S3	Carrying capacity plans for protected areas	✗ Not done	Complete for Caramoan, Calaguas, Mayon, Donsol	2027

16.2 Glossary of Terms

TERM	DEFINITION
CBT	Community-Based Tourism — tourism managed by local communities for their economic, social, and environmental benefit
MICE	Meetings, Incentives, Conventions, Exhibitions — business tourism segment
MSME	Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises — the backbone of Philippine tourism
ASEAN MRA	ASEAN Mutual Recognition Arrangement — allows tourism professionals to work across member states
BIMP-EAGA	Brunei Darussalam-Indonesia-Malaysia-Philippines East ASEAN Growth Area — subregional cooperation
Carrying Capacity	The maximum number of visitors a destination can accommodate without unacceptable impacts
Yield Management	Strategically managing pricing and capacity to maximize revenue
Overnight Ratio	Percentage of visitors who stay overnight versus day-trippers
Leakage	Tourism revenue that leaves the local economy (e.g., foreign-owned hotels, imported goods)
Multiplier Effect	The indirect and induced economic impact of each tourism dollar spent

16.3 References & Data Sources

1. ASEAN Tourism Strategic Plan 2026–2030 (ASEAN Secretariat, 2026)
2. ASEAN Tourism Marketing Strategy 2026–2030 (ASEAN Secretariat, 2026)
3. National Tourism Development Plan 2023–2028 (DOT Philippines, 2023)
4. Tourism New Zealand Strategy 2024–2028 (TNZ, 2024)
5. DOT Bicol Regional Office — Arrival Data 2024–2025
6. Philippine Statistics Authority — Regional Economic Accounts
7. World Tourism Organization (UNWTO) — Global Tourism Statistics
8. Inquirer Research — Camarines Sur Tourism Analysis (2025)
9. Philippine News Agency — DOT Bicol Reports (2024–2025)
10. Bicol Mail — Bicol Tourism Revenue Reports (2025)

16.4 Sample Content Calendar Template

DATE	PLATFORM	PILLAR	CONTENT TYPE	CAPTION THEME	ASSETS NEEDED	STATUS
June 1	Facebook	#BicolWOW	Reel	Mayon Sunrise Timelapse	Drone footage	 Planned
June 1	Instagram	#BicolGuide	Carousel	10 Budget Hotels in Legazpi	Hotel photos	 Planned
June 2	Facebook	#BicolFoodie	Photo	Laing — The Dish You Need to Try	Food photography	 Planned
June 2	TikTok	#BicolWOW	Reel	Whale Shark Encounter POV	GoPro footage	 Planned
June 3	Facebook	#BicolanoPride	Text + Photo	Did You Know? Bicol's Spanish Heritage	Research + photos	 Planned
June 3	YouTube	Travel Guide	Video	Bicol on a Budget: PHP 1,500/Day	Edited video	 Planned
June 4	Facebook	#BicolPeople	Photo + Interview	The Pili Farmer of Camarines Sur	Interview footage	 Planned
June 4	Instagram	#BicolNow	Story	Weekend Events in Naga	Event graphics	 Planned

16.5 Investment Proposal Template

For use when approaching potential investors, partners, or funding agencies:

Project Name: [Name]
Location: [Province/Municipality]
Investment Required: PHP [Amount]
Expected ROI: [Ratio] within [Timeline]
Jobs Created: [Number] direct, [Number] indirect
Alignment with ASEAN READS: [Focus Areas]
Alignment with Bicol Guidebook: [Part/Section Reference]
Sustainability Certification: [Target Level]
Contact: DOT Region V — [Office]

Bicol Region Tourism Strategic Guidebook 2026–2028

Prepared for the Department of Tourism Region V • Market and Product Development Division

Data sources: DOT Bicol Regional Office, Philippine Statistics Authority, ASEAN

Secretariat,
Tourism New Zealand, World Tourism Organization (UNWTO)
Generated using opencode-skill-pack · June 2026